Ray Key, 1977 traditional turned objects
(Craft Council Index *rejected* this application)

Ray Key, 1977 contemporary turned objects
(Craft Council Index *accepted* this application)

Gallery turners

Back in the 1970s, there were very few turners whom you could describe as gallery makers. The Raffan brothers, Cecil Jordan, Richard Kell, David Pye and myself were the main players. Apart from Kell and Pye, the rest of us underpinned our livelihoods by producing functional work. Makers like Alan Shave, Mike Fitz and Peter Spear were also active at that time.

County craft guilds

Many of the county craft guilds had been set up in the 1950s and 1960s; as the 1970s dawned they started to flourish once more after some tough times. Devon has always been one of the largest guilds, boasting many of the craft world's leading practitioners. In 1970 they held an exhibition at Shinners Bridge. Turners exhibiting were the aforementioned Dougie Hart and John Trippas, along with a new name to us, Major Lee Pym.

Liz and I arranged a visit to Major Pym; he was a wonderful guy in the Heath Robinson tradition and looked like Pinocchio's creator, Geppetto. He had a bandsaw made from bicycle wheels. I was intrigued by his square glass jars with round openings; he was turning wooden lids for these and cutting a sealing washer, freehand with scissors from neoprene. No such thing as a sophisticated 'O' ring. This was the time when every kitchen had a spice jar rack on display. He had obtained his jars by eating huge quantities of shell fish until he found the supplier. He gave me the supplier's name; I ordered a gross of them and never made one lid for them. He was quite a character.

Turning in the USA

Significant events occurred in the USA in the latter half of the 1970s, which impacted world turning. Dale Nish's first book *Creative Woodturning* was published and became a bestseller worldwide. Albert LeCoff started organising woodturning seminars in Philadelphia, twice a year for 70 people with five presenters. Taunton Press published *Fine Woodworking*, which quickly established itself as a quality publication. This magazine provided a platform for the emerging creative forces in the woodturning world and also featured those who had been groundbreakers in earlier times. These three happenings helped to change the face of woodturning for ever.

My career takes off

I was selected for the Crafts Council Index in 1977, after initially misjudging the selection process the first time round. I submitted more traditional work rather than contemporary, which was my real forte. I was rejected and advised not to re-submit for at least 12 months. I didn't take that advice; I had realised my mistake so resubmitted just six months later and was duly selected. 1977 saw my first One Man exhibition held at the Collection Gallery in Birmingham. Fortunately a lot of the right movers and shakers were impressed by this exhibition and doors opened for me. These opening doors were then forced wider open by having my work displayed at the British Craft Centre; back then, newly selected makers to the Crafts Council Index were invited to show five pieces of work. Galleries of significance would visit and see who was new on the scene, orders were placed and exhibitions offered. I am not sure things work that way today.

First International Woodturning Seminar

This was held in 1980 at John Makepeace's Furniture School and Workshops at

Simon Raffan, late 1970s amazakoue (*Guibourtia ehie*) bowl

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